

Modular Coding/Linking

Computer Engineering 1

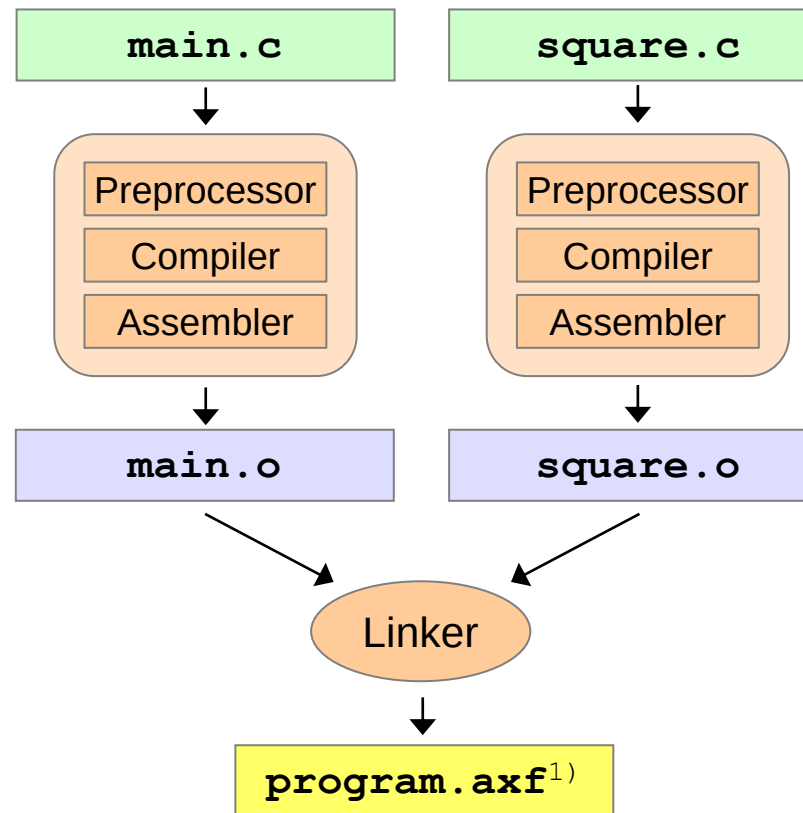
Motivation

– From source code to executable program

```
main.c
...
uint32_t square(uint32_t v);

int main(void)
{
    while(1) {
        LED = square(DIPSW);
    }
}

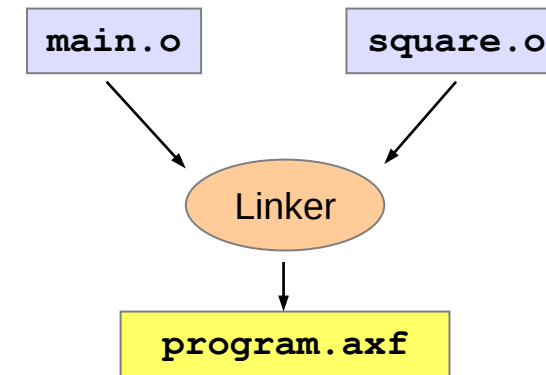
square.c
...
uint32_t square(uint32_t v)
{
    return v * v;
}
```



1) AXF file extension indicates ARM Executable File Format - other environments may have other executable formats

Agenda

- **Modular programming**
 - Why modular programming
 - Some guidelines for designing modular programs
- **From source code to the executable program**
 - Source code anatomy
 - Linker
 - Merging code sections
 - Merging data sections
 - Symbol resolution
 - Symbol relocation
- **Tools, libraries, debugging**
 - Cross compiler tool chain
 - Static libraries versus dynamic libraries
 - Source level debugging



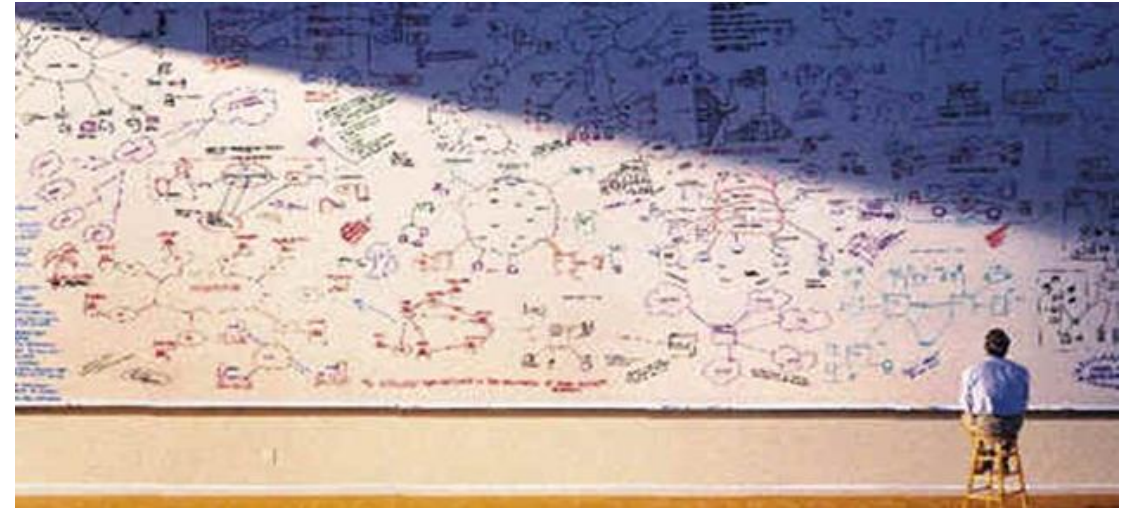
Learning Objectives

At the end of this lesson you will be able

- to explain the concepts behind modular programming
- to appropriately partition C and assembly programs into modules
- to explain the steps involved from source to the executable program
- to interpret map files of object files and executable programs
- to explain the main tasks of a linker: merging, resolution, relocation
- to explain the rules the linker applies for resolution and relocation
- to explain the difference between static and dynamic linking
- to explain the concept of source level debugging

Modular Programming – Overview

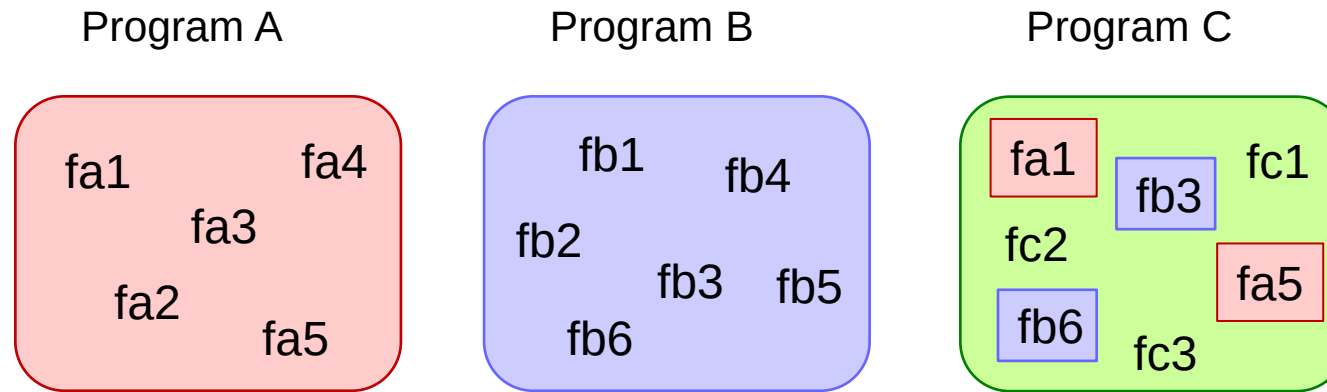
- **Why modular programming?**
 - To manage complexity!
- **Basic rules**
 - Group together what belongs together
 - Split what does not belong together
 - Don't repeat code
 - Make modules, types, and functions instead
 - Enables reusing of existing code
- **Intellectual effort**
 - There is no golden rule but established practice



1) Image source: <http://www.marketingsavant.com/wp-content/uploads/2010/06/Complexity650300.jpg>

Modular Programming

- **Example: Problem of non-modular programming**



- Three single-module programs – no shared code
 - Program C needs parts from program A and B
 - Program C has copies of parts from A and B
 - Changing code and fixing bugs requires effort on multiple sources

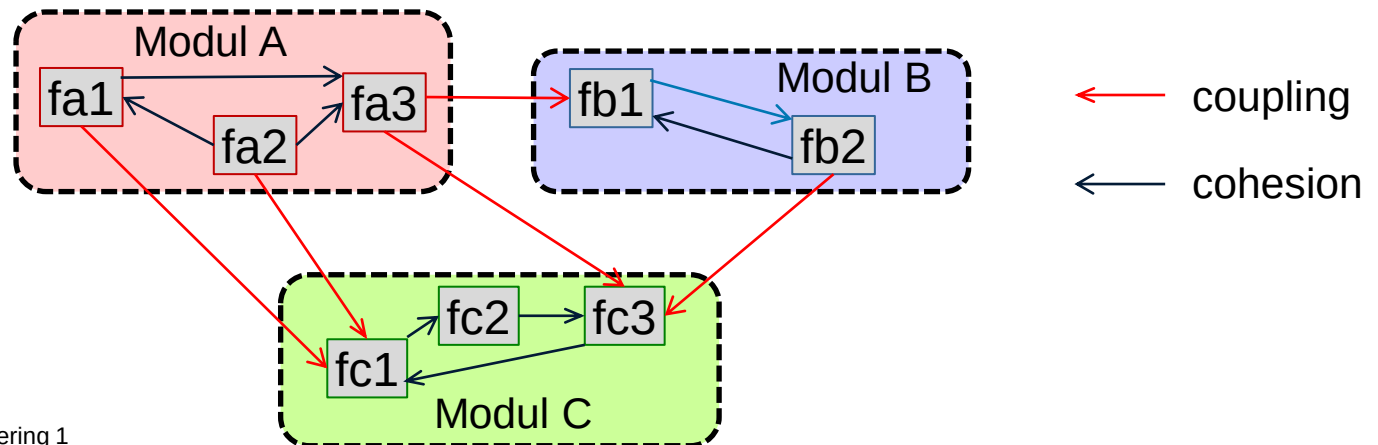
Modular Programming

– Managing complexity by modular programming

Topic	Benefits
Enable working in teams	Multiple developers working on the same source repository
Useful partitioning and structuring of the programs	Eases reusing of modules
Individual verification of each module	Benefits all users of the module
Providing libraries of types and functions	For reuse instead of reinvention
Mixing of modules that are programmed in various languages	E.g. mix C and assembly language modules
Only compile the changed modules	Speeds up compilation time

Modular Programming – Guidelines

- **High module cohesion**
 - Group together what belongs together
 - Lean external interface
 - Idea: each module fulfills a **single** defined task
- **Low module coupling**
 - Split what does not belong together
 - Little dependencies between modules



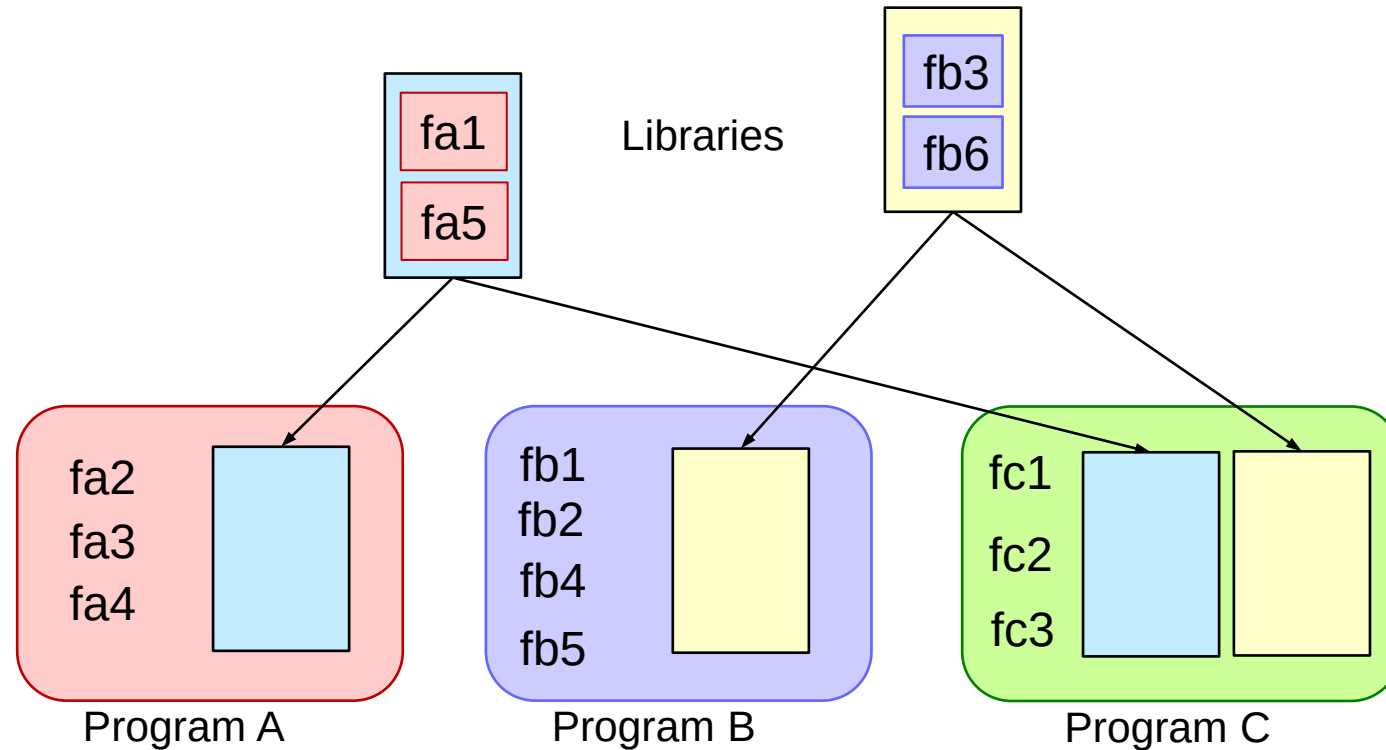
Modular Programming – Guidelines

- **Divide and conquer**
 - Partition functionality into manageable chunks
 - Hierarchical design
- **Information hiding**
 - Split interface from implementation
 - Do not disclose unnecessary details
 - Maintain freedom to change implementation details

Modular Programming – Guidelines

- **Reuse**

- Libraries of functions and types to enable reuse



Modular Programming – Design

- **Module design and implementation**
 - Definition of module interface
 - Defines what functionality is available to the client of the code
 - Implementation of module
 - Provides the functionality behind the interface
 - An interface may have alternative implementations
 - Individual testing of each module
 - Modules can be tested individually if designed accordingly
 - Reuse of existing modules in new modules
 - Modules should be designed such that they can be reused

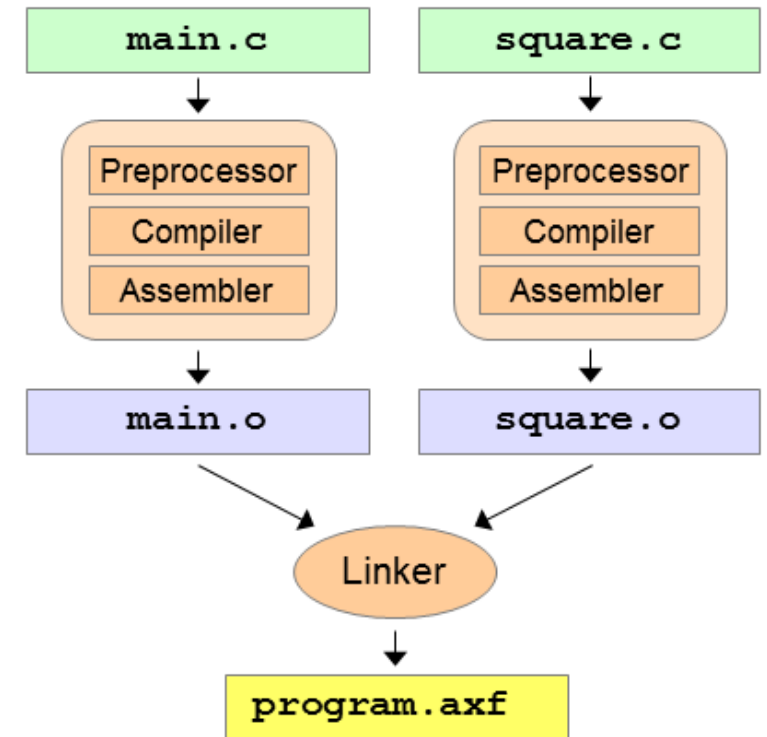
.h file

.c file

Modular Programming – Translation

- **Translation steps**

- Compile/assemble each module
 - Results in an object file for each module (module.o¹⁾)
- Link all object files
 - Results in one executable file²⁾



1) The file extension may vary depending on the environment

2) See later slides of this lecture

Source Code Anatomy – Overview

- **Partitioning into modules**

- Modular programming: the whole source code base is split into multiple source files¹⁾
- Each source file defines a module
- Each source file gets translated into one object file
- The object files get linked into an executable file

- **Implications for source code**

- C declarations and definitions
- Header files to share commonly used declarations
- Linkage of declarations and definitions
- From C-declarations and C-definitions to assembly symbols
- From assembly symbols to object file symbols

1) Source files are the ones that hold the core code of the module - header files are discussed later in this lecture

Source Code Anatomy

- **Challenge**

- Modular programming requires concepts where
 - Types, functions and variables may be defined in other modules than where they are used
 - Consistency of types, functions and variables is maintained across module boundaries

- **Solution**

- Terminology: declarations and definitions
- Declared-before-used
- One-definition-rule

Source Code Anatomy

- **C: Declaration vs. definition**

- **Declaration**

- Specifies how a name can be used¹⁾

```
uint32_t square(uint32_t v); // square function defined elsewhere
extern uint32_t counter;    // counter variable defined elsewhere
struct S;                  // struct S type defined elsewhere
```

- **Definition²⁾**

- Where a function is given with its body
 - Where memory is allocated for a variable
 - A struct type with its members

```
uint32_t square(uint32_t v) { ... } // square function definition
uint32_t counter;                  // counter variable definition
struct S { ... };                  // struct S type definition
```

1) Function and type declarations do not need the «extern» keyword

2) Each definition is implicitly also a declaration of the given name

Source Code Anatomy

- **Some C rules: what is legal and what is illegal code**

- **Names declared before use**

- Each name must be declared before it can be used
 - Note: a definition is also a declaration

```
uint32_t square(uint32_t v); // square is declared before use
...
out = square(in); // square is known at the point of use
```

- **One-definition-rule**

- A variable or function may be declared multiple times
 - But may be defined only once in the same scope¹⁾

```
uint32_t in = 5; // legal first definition of the variable in
uint32_t in = 5; // illegal second definition of in
```

1) The exact rules are more elaborate

Source Code Anatomy

- **Challenge: reuse of declarations**

- Declared-before-used may result in repeating declarations in multiple source files

```
// program_A.c

// declaration of square
uint32 t square(uint32 t v);
...
int main(void) {
    // use of square
    res = square(a) + b;
    ...
}
```

```
// program_B.c

// declaration of square
uint32 t square(uint32 t v);
...
int main(void) {
    // use of square
    y = square(x);
    ...
}
```

- **Maintenance issues**

- Duplicated declarations are a consistency problem

Source Code Anatomy

- **Solution: use of header files**

- Use a single header file instead of duplicating declarations
- Avoids copy/paste of declarations
- Maintains consistency over time

```
// square.h
#ifndef _SQUARE_H_ // incl.-
#define _SQUARE_H_ // guard

// declaration of square
uint32 t square(uint32 t v);

#endif // end of incl.-guard
```

```
// square.c
#include "square.h"

// definition of square
uint32 t square(uint32 t v)
{
    return v*v;
}
```

- Usage through **#include** preprocessor directive

```
// program_A.c
#include "square.h"
int main(void) {
    res = square(a) + b;
    ...
}
```

```
// program_B.c
#include "square.h"
int main(void) {
    y = square(x);
    ...
}
```

Source Code Anatomy

- **Challenge: Which names can be used by other modules?**¹⁾
 - How to provide names that can be used by other modules?
 - How to inhibit use of internal names by other modules?
- **Solution: Concept of linkage in C**¹⁾
 - External linkage
 - The global name is externally available for use in any modules
 - E.g. a function or a global variable
 - Internal linkage
 - The global name is only internally available for use in this module
 - E.g. a function or a global variable
 - No linkage
 - Any name that is not in the global space

1) I.e. names that are subject to symbol resolution in the linker process

Source Code Anatomy

- **Example: Internal and external linkage (C)**

- All global names have external linkage unless defined **static**

```
// square.c
...
uint32_t square(uint32_t v) {
    return v*v;
}
```

square = external linkage

```
// main.c
#include "square.h"
static uint32_t a = 5;
static uint32_t b = 7;
int main(void) {
    uint32_t res;
    res = square(a) + b;
    ...
}
```

a = internal linkage
b = internal linkage
main = external linkage
res = no linkage
square = external linkage¹⁾

1) square has external linkage (no static keyword), but no definition in main.c – needs to be resolved by the linker

Source Code Anatomy

- **From C declaration/definition to assembly symbol**
 - Names given in C translate into symbols in assembly
 - C-definitions with external linkage translate into EXPORT symbols in assembly
 - C-declarations with external linkage which are used but not defined in the module translate into IMPORT symbols in assembly

```
// square.c
...
uint32_t square(uint32_t v) {
    return v*v;
}
```

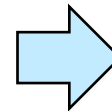


```
@ square.s
.text
.global square
square:
    mov     r1,r0
    muls    r0,r1,r0
    bx      lr
```

Source Code Anatomy

- ARM assembly `.extern` and `.global` keywords
 - Linkage control
 - `.global` declares a symbol for use by other modules
 - `.extern` declares a symbol from another module for use in this module
 - Internal symbols
 - Neither `.global` nor `.extern`
 - Defined in this module
 - Can only be used within this module

```
// main.c
#include "square.h"
static uint32_t a = 5;
static uint32_t b = 7;
int main(void) {
    uint32_t res;
    res = square(a) + b;
    ...
}
```



```
@ main.s
.text
.global main
.extern square
main:
    ldr    r0, a_adr
    ldr    r0, [r0, #0]    @ a
    bl     square
    ...

a_adr: .word a
b_adr: .word b

.data
a      .word    0x00000005
b      .word    0x00000007
```

usable outside of module main

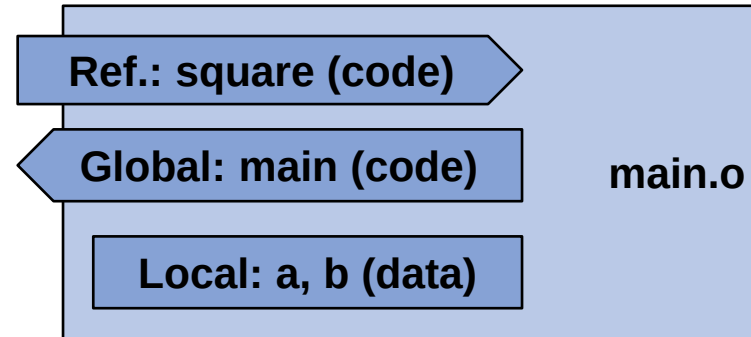
from module square

internal symbols

Source Code Anatomy

- From assembly symbols to object file symbols

```
.extern square
...
.global main
main: ...
...
a:    ...
b:    ...
```



- References

- .extern symbols from assembly code translate to global reference symbols in the object file

- Global

- .global symbols from assembly code translate to global symbols in the object file

- Local

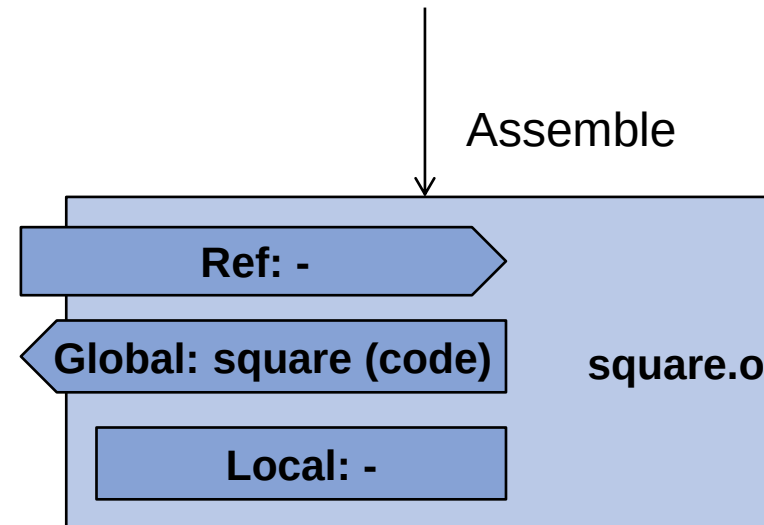
- Internal symbols from assembly code translate to local symbols in the object file

Source Code Anatomy

- **Example: Assembly to object file**

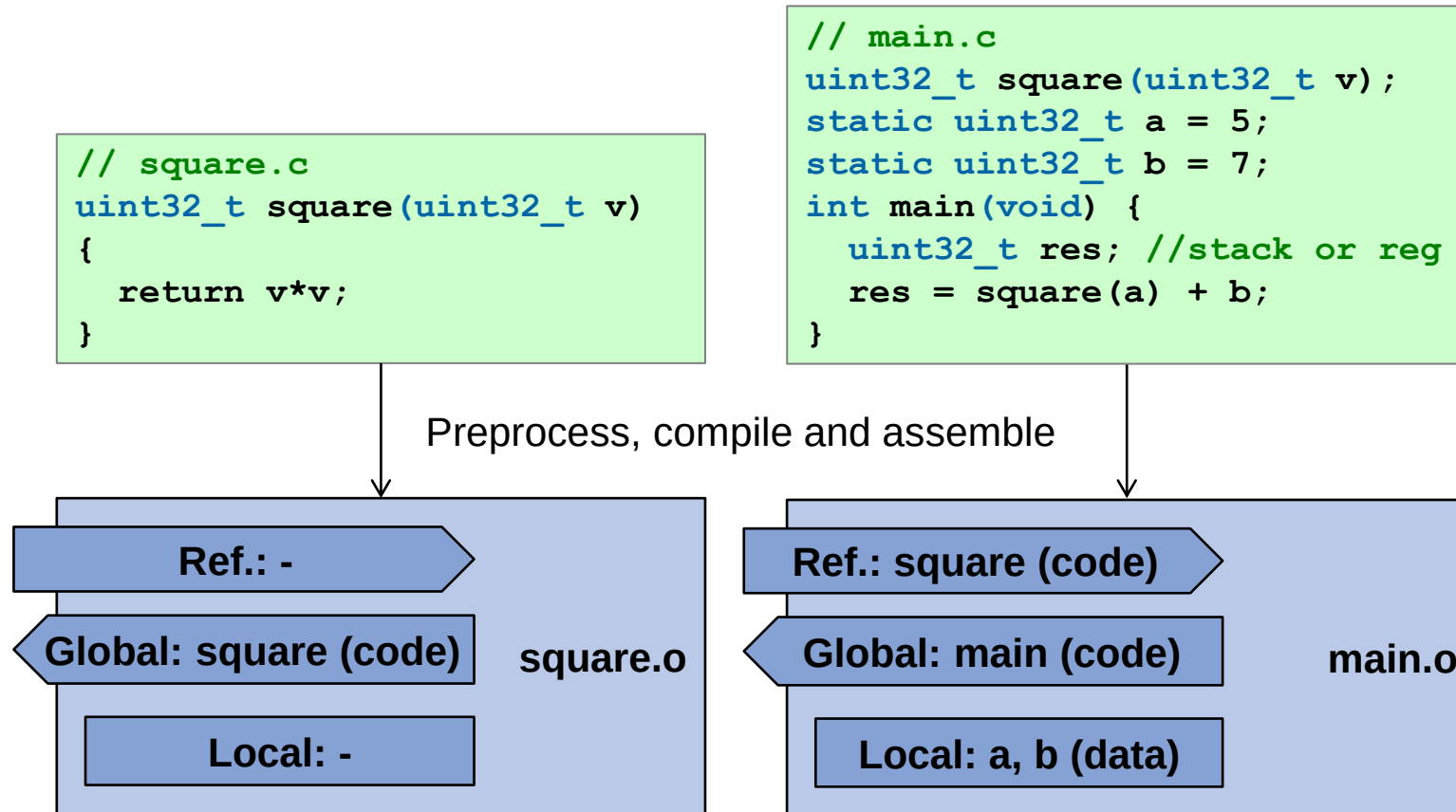
- .global
 - Code symbol **square**
- Referenced/.extern
 - None
 - No external symbol used
- Local
 - None
 - No internal symbol defined

```
@ square.s
.text
.global square
square:
    mov     r1,r0
    muls    r0,r1,r0
    bx      lr
```

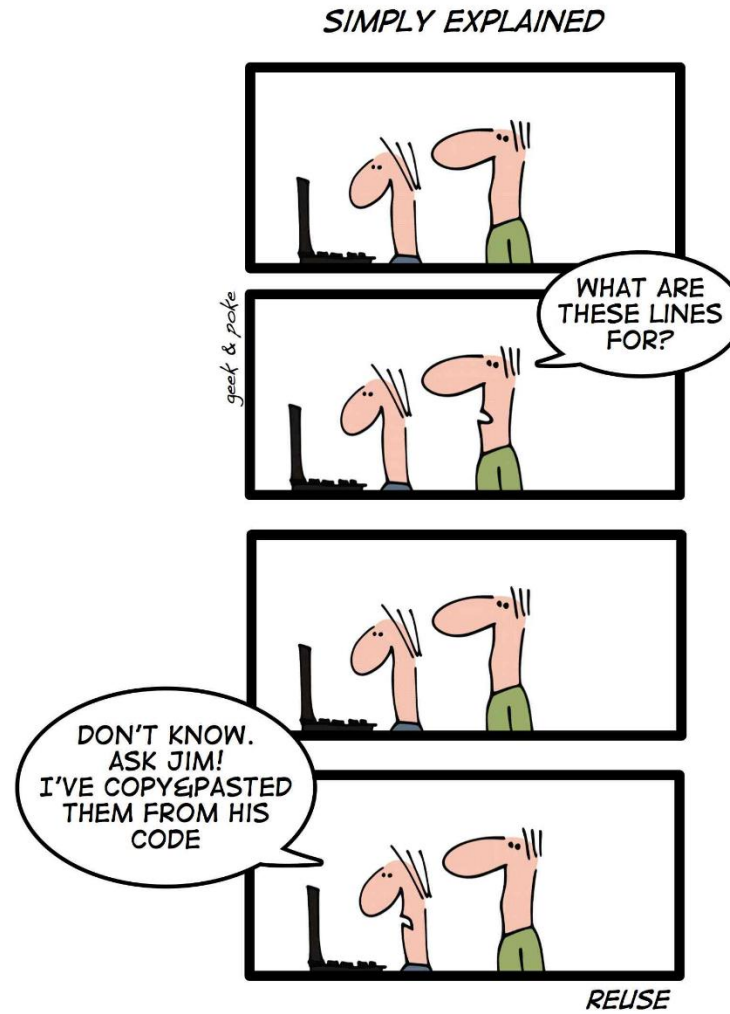


Source Code Anatomy

– Example: C to object file



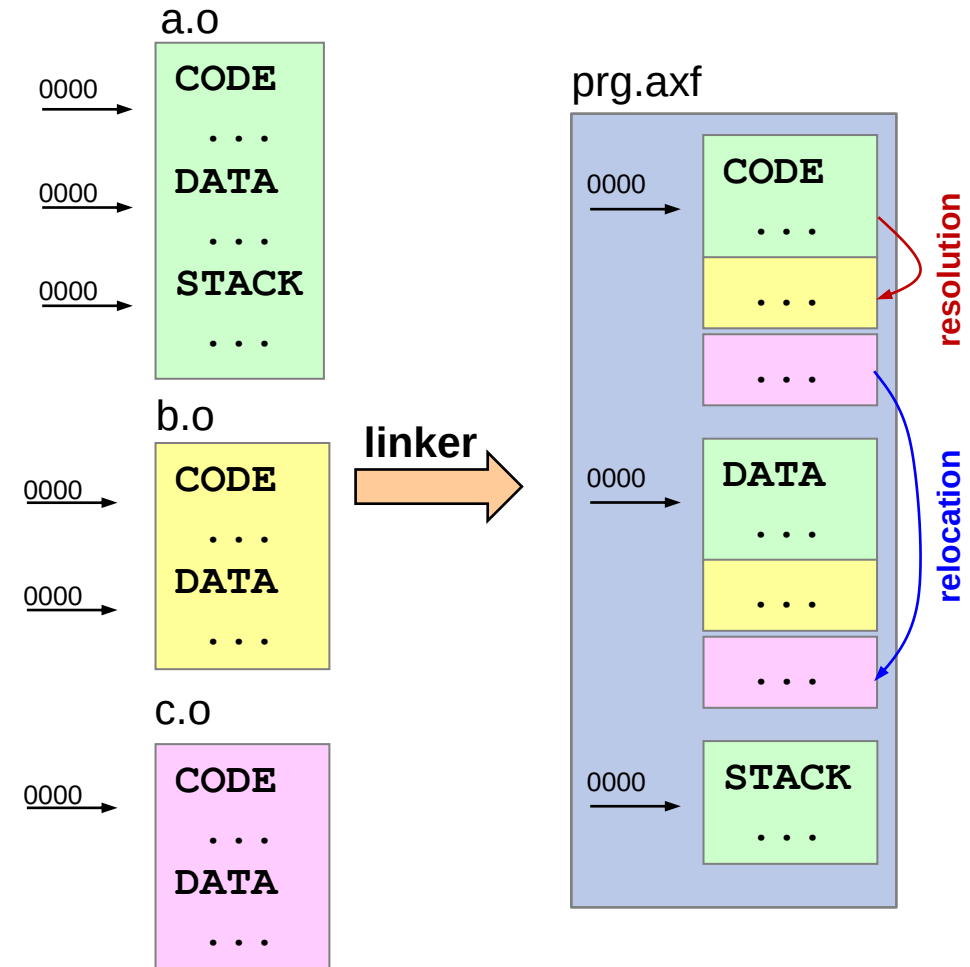
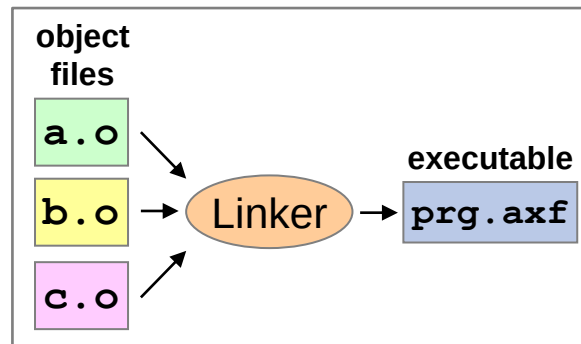
Motivation



Linker – Overview

– Linker tasks

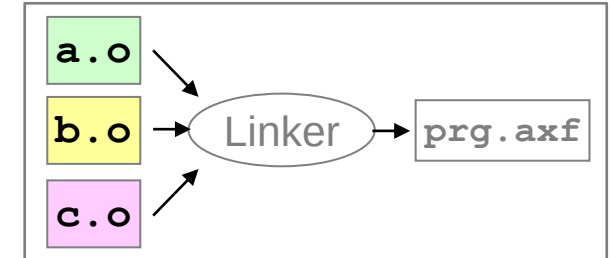
- Merge code sections
- Merge data sections
- Symbol resolution
 - References to other modules
- Address relocation
 - Adapt to new positions of symbols



Linker Input: Object Files

- **Object files**

- Contain all compiled data of a module
 - Code section
 - Code and constant data of the module, based at address 0x0
 - Data section
 - All global variables of the module, based at address 0x0
 - Symbol table
 - All symbols with their attributes like global/local, reference, etc.
 - Relocation table
 - Which bytes of the data and code section need to be adjusted (and how) after merging the sections in the linking process
- **ARM tool chain uses ELF for object files**
 - ELF = **E**xecutable and **L**inkable **F**ormat
 - Includes the above mentioned sections as well as further sections (e.g. string tables, debugging information, etc.)



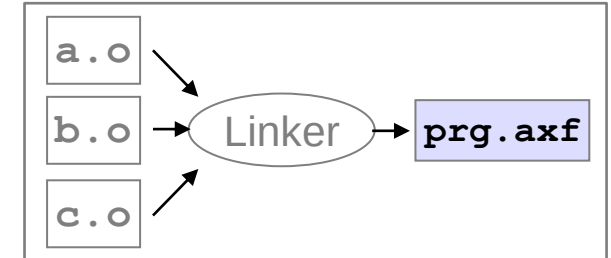
Linker Output: Executable File

- **Executable file**

- Contains all linked data of the program
 - Code section
 - Code and constant data of the program
 - Data section
 - All global variables of the program
 - Symbol table
 - All symbols with their attributes like global/local, etc.
- If the program is loaded before execution (by a loader of the hosting operating system), there might still be¹⁾
 - Unresolved symbols for linking with shared (dynamic linked) libraries
 - A relocation table to move the program/data to fixed locations

- **ARM tool chain uses ELF for executable file**

- File extension: AXF = **A**RM **eX**ecutable **F**ile



1) In CT1/CT2, we have no hosting OS, so we place the program sections at fixed memory locations – no loader involved

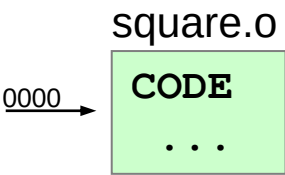
Notes on toolchains and their differences

- Used Toolchains
 - Keil uVision: ARM Clang compiler tools → on Windows
 - GNU: arm-none-eabi compiler tools → on Windows, Linux, MacOS
- ARM Clang compiler tools
 - C-Compiler: **armcc** → generate AAPCS based ELF files
 - ELF-file dump: **fromelf** → generates human readable ELF content/disassembly
- arm-none-eabi compiler tools
 - C-Compiler: **arm-none-eabi-gcc** → generate AAPCS based ELF files
 - ELF-file dump: **arm-none-eabi-readelf** → generates human readable ELF content
 - Disassemble: **arm-none-eabi-objdump** → generates assembly text from ELF content
- Differences
 - The object files generated by the toolchains can in theory be mixed if some attributes are carefully set at compilation time, but it is not advised to do so since ready-to-use libraries such as the standard libraries might not be compiled accordingly → best practice: do not mix
 - In the sample codes of the following slides, the output might be once from the ARM Keil and once from the arm-none-eabi toolchains. Even if the format details may differ, the content is the same.

Example ELF Object File

- **square.o**
- Keil fromelf:
 - Section #1: code section (**.text**)
 - **square** starts at local address **0x0**
 - Section #5: symbol table (**.symtab**)
 - **square** is an exported symbol (**Gb**) from section #1 (**code** section)

```
File Type: ET_REL (Relocatable object) (1)
...
** Section #1 '.text' (SHT_PROGBITS) [SHF_ALLOC + SHF_EXECINSTR]
Address: 0x00000000
square
0x00000000: 4601 .F MOV r1,r0
0x00000002: 4608 .F MOV r0,r1
0x00000004: 4348 HC MULS r0,r1,r0
0x00000006: 4770 pG BX lr
...
** Section #5 '.symtab' (SHT_SYMTAB)
# Symbol Name Value Bind Sec Type Vis Size
=====
6 square 0x00000001 Gb 1 Code Hi 0x8
```



- 1) The output is obtained with:
`fromelf.exe --text -c -d -r -s -z square.o`
- 2) Similar output is obtained by a combination of
`arm-none-eabi-readelf -s -r square.o`
`arm-none-eabi-objdump -d square.o`

- GNU arm-none-eabi-objdump:
 - produces assembly text only
 - **square** starts at local address **0**

```
00000000 <square>:
0: 4340      muls    r0, r0
2: 4770      bx      lr
```

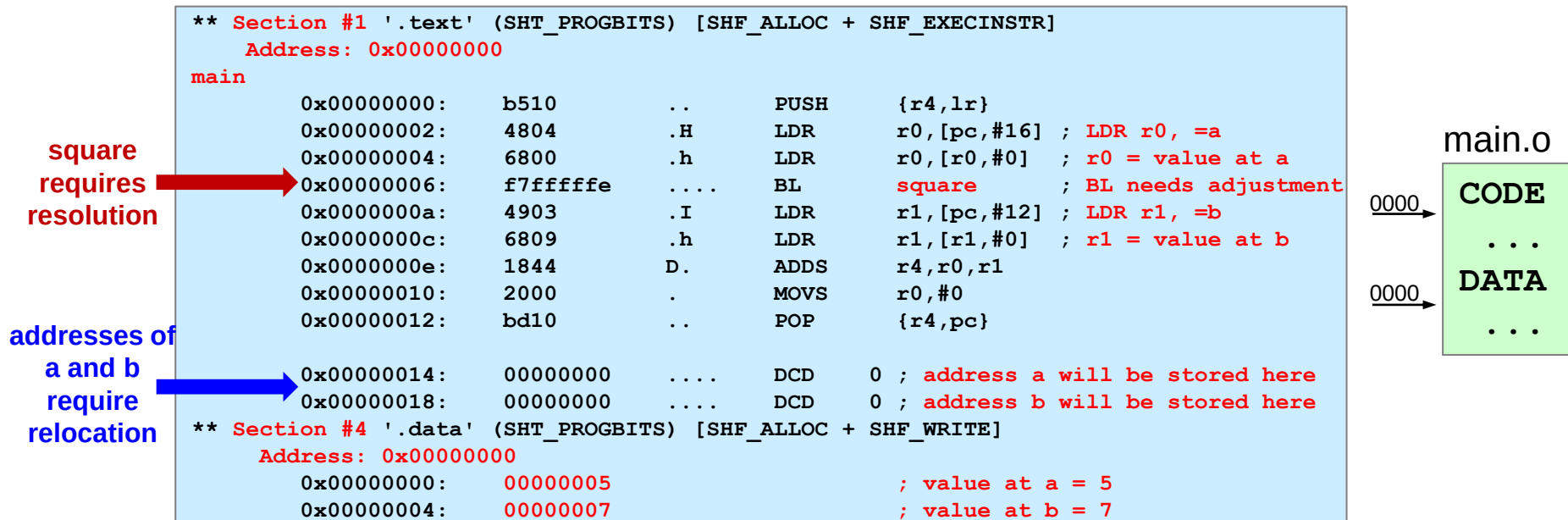
- GNU arm-none-eabi-readelf:
 - Section **.symtab**
 - **square** is an exported symbol (**GLOBAL**) from section #1 and is code (**FUNC**)

```
Symbol table '.symtab' contains 16 entries:
Num:  Value  Size Type  Bind  Vis      Ndx Name
...
15: 00000001    4 FUNC  GLOBAL DEFAULT  1 square
```

Example ELF Object File

- 1) The output is obtained with:
`fromelf.exe --text -c -d -r -s -z square.o`
- 2) Similar output is obtained by a combination of
`arm-none-eabi-readelf -s -r square.o`
`arm-none-eabi-objdump -d square.o`

- **main.o (part I – only KEIL variant shown)**
 - File section #1: code section, at base address **0x00000000**
 - **0x00000002**: **LDR r0, =a** (address **a** stored at 0x14)
 - **0x0000000a**: **LDR r1, =b** (address **b** stored at 0x18)
 - **BL square** calls a dummy address until linked
 - File section #4: data section, at base address **0x00000000**



Example ELF Object File

- main.o (part II – only KEIL variant shown)
 - Symbols (**.symtab**):
 - **a**: local data section symbol, at offset 0x00000000
 - **b**: local data section symbol, at offset 0x00000004
 - **main**: global code section symbol, at offset 0x00000000 (LSB set: Thumb code)
 - **square**: global symbol, Ref(erenced)/UND(EFINED) (no definition in main.o)

Keil armcc

```
...
** Section #6 '.symtab' (SHT_SYMTAB)
# Symbol Name Value Bind Sec Type Vis Size
=====
7 a 0x00000000 Lc 4 Data De 0x4
8 b 0x00000004 Lc 4 Data De 0x4
11 main 0x00000001 Gb 1 Code Hi 0x14
12 square 0x00000000 Gb Ref Code Hi
...
```

GNU arm-none-eabi

```
...
Symbol table '.symtab' contains 23 entries:

Num: Value Size Type Bind Vis Ndx Name
9: 00000000 4 OBJECT LOCAL DEFAULT 2 a
10: 00000004 4 OBJECT LOCAL DEFAULT 2 b
21: 00000001 20 FUNC GLOBAL DEFAULT 4 main
22: 00000000 0 NOTYPE GLOBAL DEFAULT UND square
...
```

Example ELF Object File

- **main.o (part III – only KEIL variant shown)**

- File section #7: relocation table:

- Relocation at code address **0x00000006**:

- Modify the **BL call** to branch to the symbol **square**

- Relocation at code address

- 0x00000014**:

- Set the **absolute 32 bit** value of the symbol **a**

- Relocation at code address

- 0x00000018**:

- Set the **absolute 32 bit** value of the symbol **b**

Relocation table section

```
...
** Section #7 '.rel.text' (SHT_REL)
#      Offset      Relocation Type      Wrt Symbol
=====
0  0x00000006    10 R_ARM_THM_CALL      12 square
1  0x00000014     2 R_ARM_ABS32        7 a
2  0x00000018     2 R_ARM_ABS32        8 b
...
```

Affected code section locations

```
** Section #1 '.text' (SHT_PROGBITS) [SHF_ALLOC + SHF_EXECINSTR]
...
0x00000006:  f7ffffffe    ....    BL      square      ; BL needs adjustment
...
0x00000014:  00000000    ....    DCD     0 ; address a will be stored here
0x00000018:  00000000    ....    DCD     0 ; address b will be stored here
```

Tasks of a Linker – Overview

- **Tasks of a Linker**

- **Merge object file data sections**

- Place all data sections of the individual object files into one data section of the executable file

- **Merge object file code sections**

- Place all code sections of the individual object files into one code section of the executable file

- **Resolve used external symbols**

- Search missing addresses of used external symbols

- **Relocate addresses**

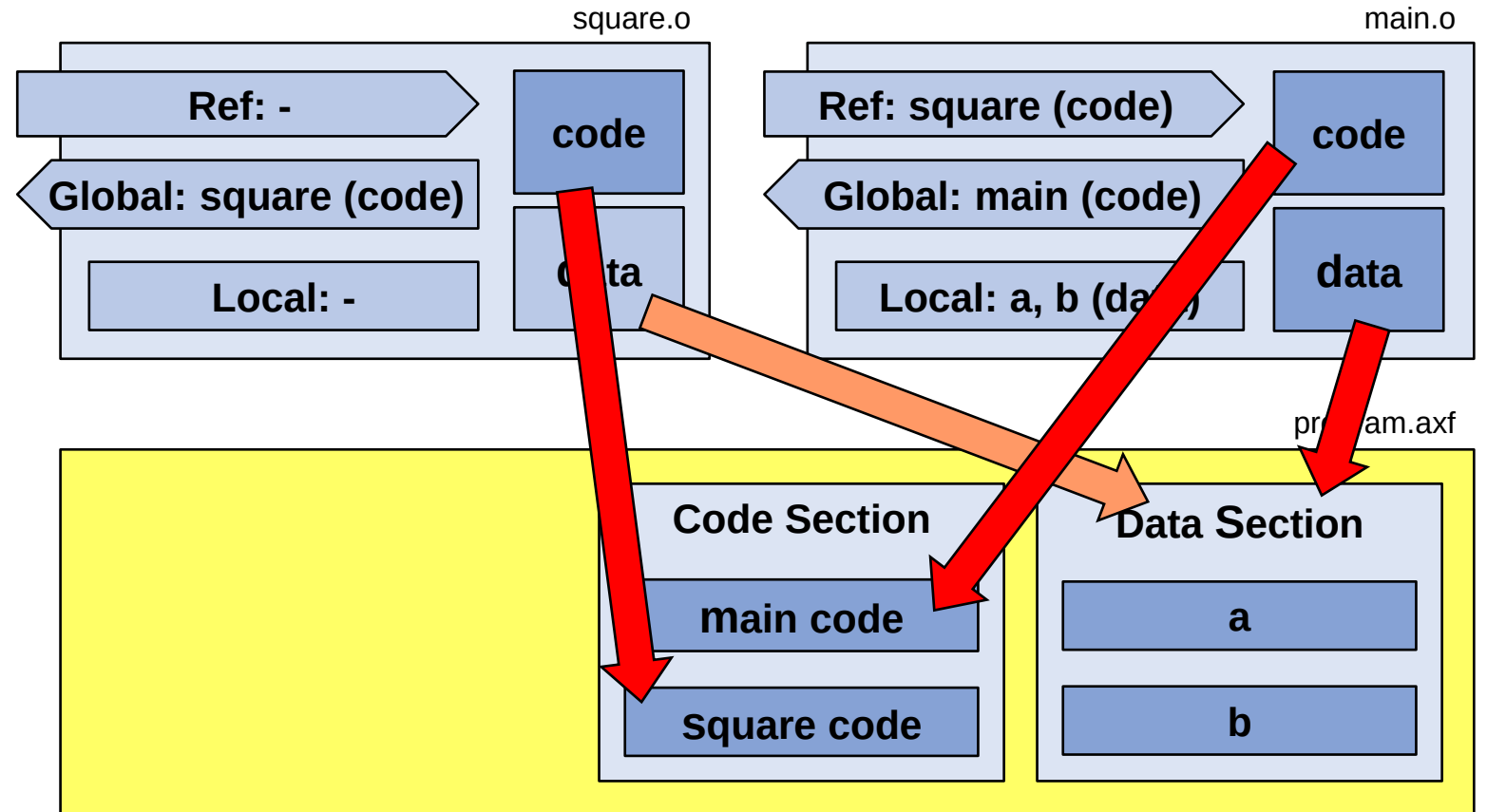
- Adjust used addresses since merging the sections invalidated the original addresses¹⁾

1) The linker places the sections depending on the target system, the given command line arguments and the scatter file (if given). A scatter file tells at which absolute addresses the code and data sections are placed. In an OS-hosted environment, addresses for code and data sections are at a fixed “virtual” address. The loader then places the sections into suitable virtual process memory.

Tasks of a Linker

- **Merge data sections and code sections of the modules**

- Place one section after the other
 - Note: in this example, square.o has no data section



Tasks of a Linker – Example

- **Example: Merge code sections (only KEIL variant shown)**
 - Merging code sections of main.o and square.o
 - Offset for first code section is **0x00000000** (main.o)
 - Offset for next code section is **0x0000001C** (square.o)

0x00000000	B510	PUSH	{r4,lr}	code (main.o)
0x00000002	4804	LDR	r0,[pc,#16]	
0x00000004	6800	LDR	r0,[r0,#0x00]	
0x00000006	f7fffffe	BL	square	
0x0000000A	4903	LDR	r1,[pc,#12]	
0x0000000C	6809	LDR	r1,[r1,#0x00]	
0x0000000E	1844	ADDS	r4,r0,r1	
0x00000010	2000	MOVS	r0,#0x00	
0x00000012	BD10	POP	{r4,pc}	
0x00000014	00000000	DCD	0x00000000	
0x00000018	00000000	DCD	0x00000000	
0x0000001C	4601	MOV	r1,r0	code (square.o)
0x0000001E	4608	MOV	r0,r1	
0x00000020	4348	MULS	r0,r1,r0	
0x00000022	4770	BX	lr	

- No resolution nor relocation done yet

Tasks of a Linker – Example

- **Example: Merge data sections (only KEIL variant shown)**
 - Merging data sections of main.o and square.o
 - Offset for first data section is **0x00000000** (main.o)
 - There is no further data section (square.o has no global data)

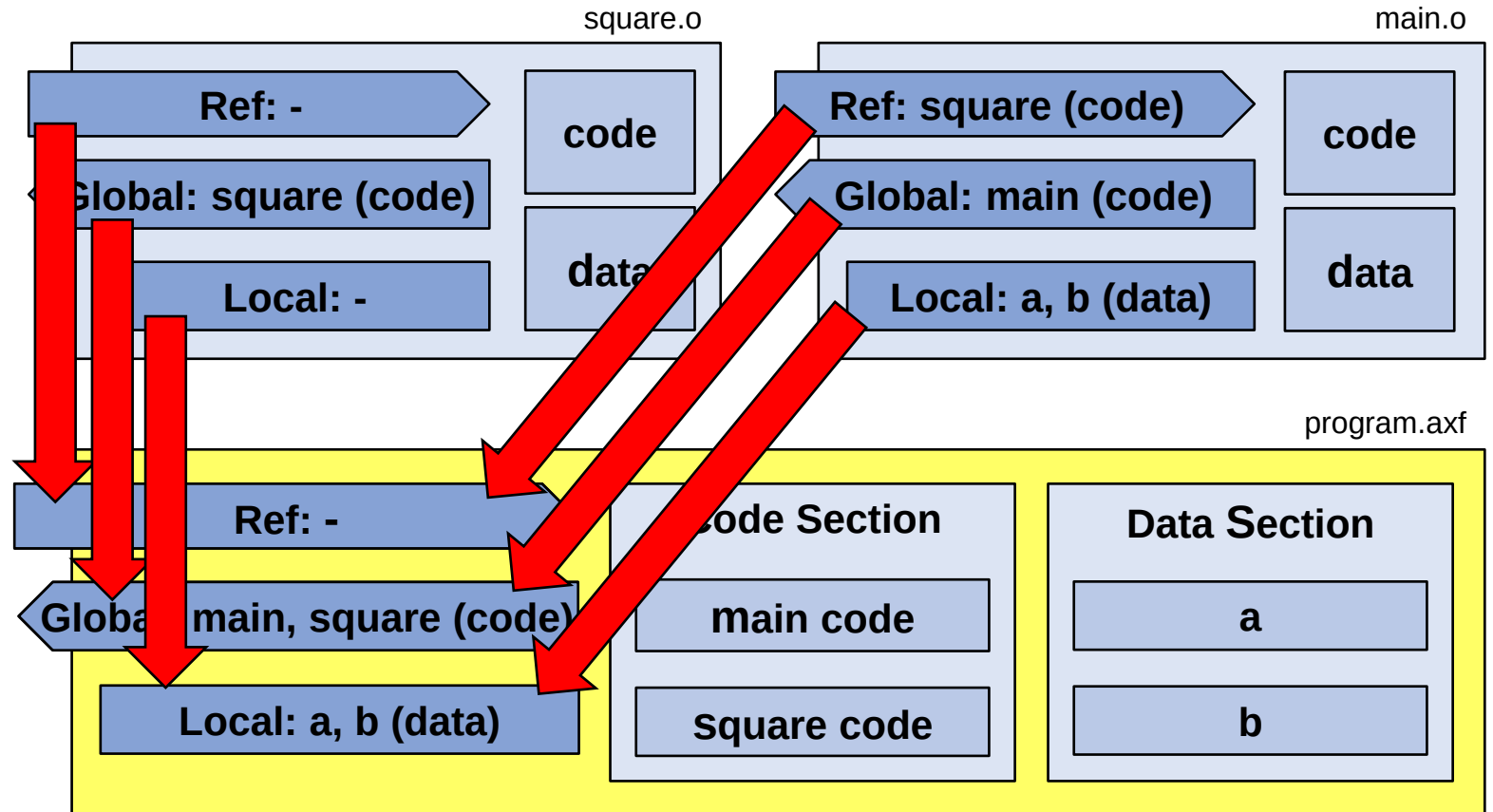
0x00000000	05000000	DCD	5	data (main.o)
0x00000004	07000000	DCD	7	

- No resolution nor relocation done yet

Tasks of a Linker – Resolution

- **Resolve referenced symbols**

- Merge the symbol tables
- Resolve references within symbol table



Tasks of a Linker – Example

- Example: Resolve symbols (only KEIL variant shown)
 - Merging symbol table sections of main.o and square.o

#	Symbol Name	Value	Bind	Sec	Type	Vis	Size	
symbols (main.o)								
7	a	0x00000000	Lc	4	Data	De	0x4	
8	b	0x00000004	Lc	4	Data	De	0x4	
11	main	0x00000001	Gb	1	Code	Hi	0x14	
12	square	0x00000000	Gb	Ref	Code	Hi		

#	Symbol Name	Value	Bind	Sec	Type	Vis	Size	
symbols (square.o)								
6	square	0x00000001	Gb	1	Code	Hi	0x8	

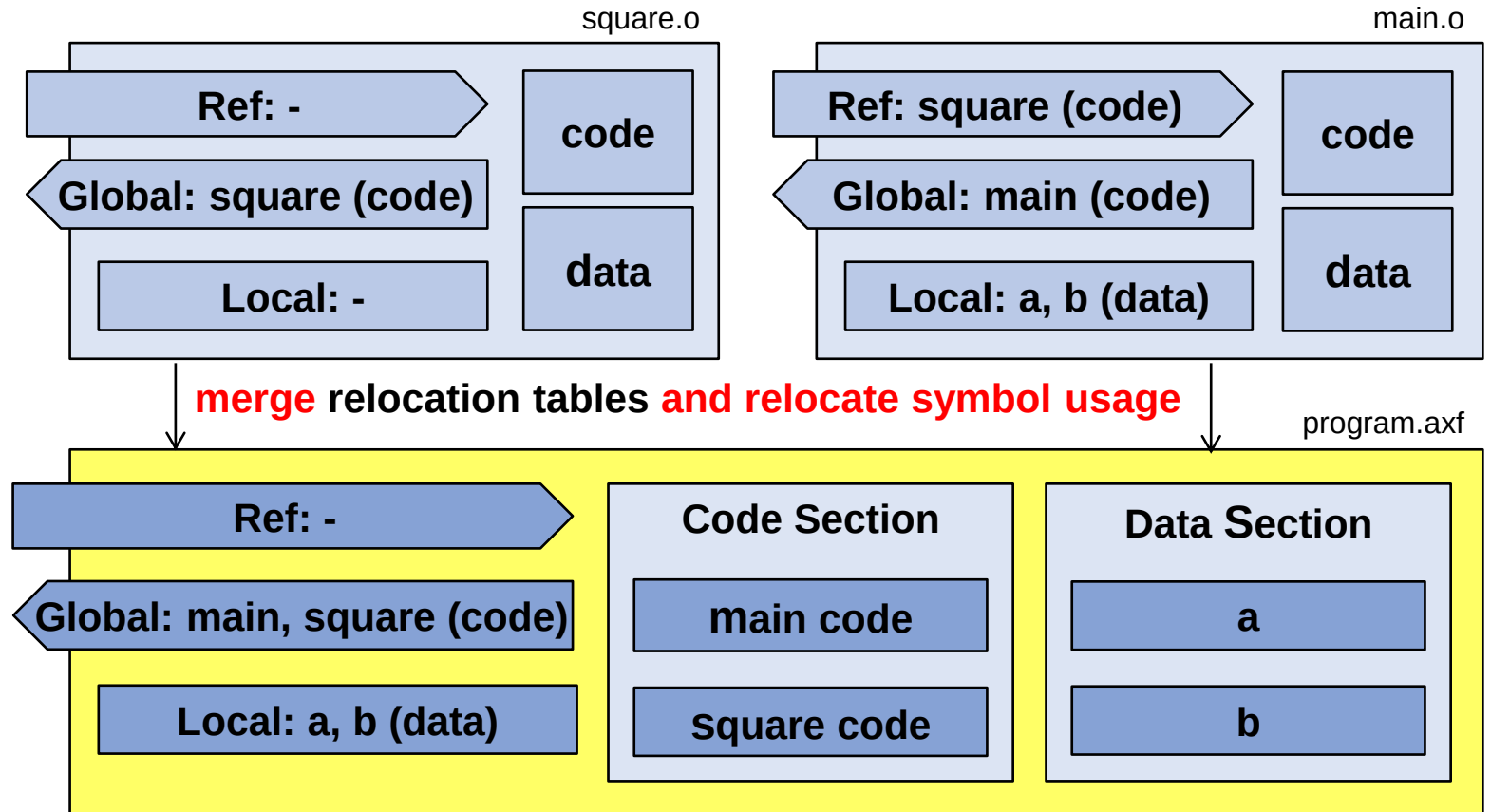
↓

#	Symbol Name	Value	Bind	Sec	Type	Vis	Size	
resolved symbols								
20	a	0x00000000	Lc	4	Data	De	0x4	(main.o)
21	b	0x00000004	Lc	4	Data	De	0x4	(main.o)
186	main	0x00000001	Gb	1	Code	Hi	0x14	(main.o)
187	square	0x00000000	Gb	1	Code	Hi	0x8	(square.o)

- The relative values of the symbols within the modules are not yet relocated to global addresses. Therefore, the linker needs to remember for which module/section the relative address is given
- No relocation done yet

Tasks of a Linker – Relocation

- Relocate usage of symbols
 - Merge the relocation tables
 - Relocate code and data section, symbols, relocation table
- Adjust code according to the relocation table



Tasks of a Linker – Example

- **Example: Relocate sections and usage of symbols (I) (only KEIL variant shown)**
 - Merging relocation table sections of main.o and square.o
 - square.o has no relocation table

merged relocation

#	Offset	Relocation Type	Wrt Symbol	
0	0x00000006	10 R_ARM_THM_CALL	12 square	(main.o)
1	0x00000014	2 R_ARM_ABS32	7 a	(main.o)
2	0x00000018	2 R_ARM_ABS32	8 b	(main.o)

- The relative address of the relocation table within the modules is not yet adjusted to global addresses, therefore, needs to remember for which module and which section the relative address is given

Tasks of a Linker – Example

– Example: Relocate sections and usage of symbols (II)

1) Relocate

- Sections
- Symbols
- Relocation offsets

Relocation calculations

– **new value = global base + merge offset + module relative offset**

– E.g. symbol **b**:

- global base = internal SRAM = 0x20000000
- merge offset = 1st in merged data section = 0x00000000
- module relative offset = b is the 2nd variable after a = 0x00000004
- new value for symbol b = 0x20000004

– E.g. symbol **square** if user code (like main) starts at 0x08000254

- $0x08000254 + 0x0000001C + 0x00000000 = \underline{0x08000270}$

2) Adjust the code according to the relocation table

Tasks of a Linker – Example

- Example: Relocate sections and usage of symbols (III) (only KEIL variant shown)

- **Relocated** code sections

0x08000254	B510	PUSH	{r4,lr}	; main
0x08000256	4804	LDR	r0,[pc,#16]	
...				
0x08000270	4601	MOV	r1,r0	; square
0x08000272	4608	MOV	r0,r1	
...				

- **Relocated** data sections

0x20000000	00000005	DCD	5	; value of a
0x20000004	00000007	DCD	7	; value of b

- **Relocated** symbols

20	a	0x20000000	Lc	4	Data	De	0x4
21	b	0x20000004	Lc	4	Data	De	0x4
186	main	0x08000255	Gb	1	Code	Hi	0x14
187	square	0x08000270	Gb	1	Code	Hi	0x8

- **Relocated** relocation table entries

0	0x0800025A	10	R_ARM_THM_CALL	12	square
1	0x08000268	2	R_ARM_ABS32	7	a
2	0x0800026C	2	R_ARM_ABS32	8	b

- **Adjusted** code locations according to relocation table

...					
0x0800025A	F000F809	BL.W	square	; 0x08000270	
...					
0x08000268	20000000	DCD	0x20000000		
0x0800026C	20000004	DCD	0x20000004		

Tool Chain, Libraries, Debugging

- **Tool chain**

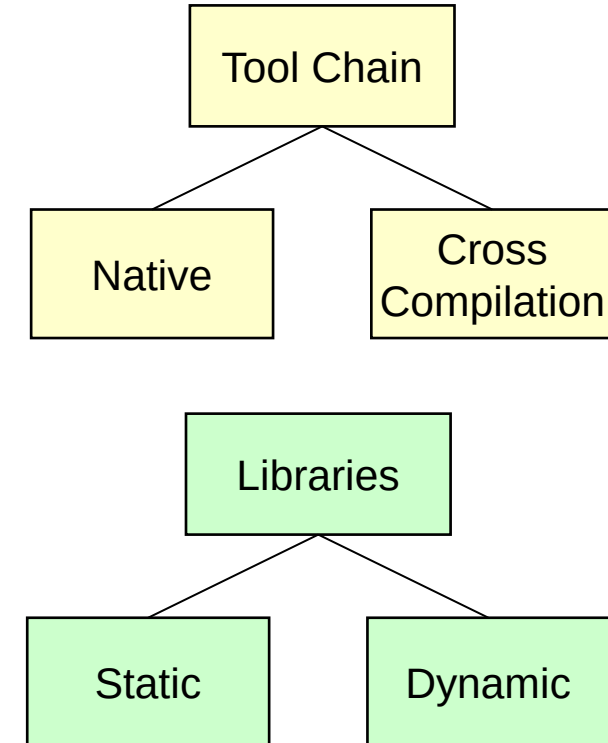
- Native tool chain
- Cross compiler tool chain

- **Libraries**

- Libraries
 - Collection of object files
- Static libraries
 - Linked into the executable at link time
- Dynamic or shared libraries
 - Executable is linked at loading time with the shared library

- **Debugging**

- Single step and breakpoints
- Source level debugger

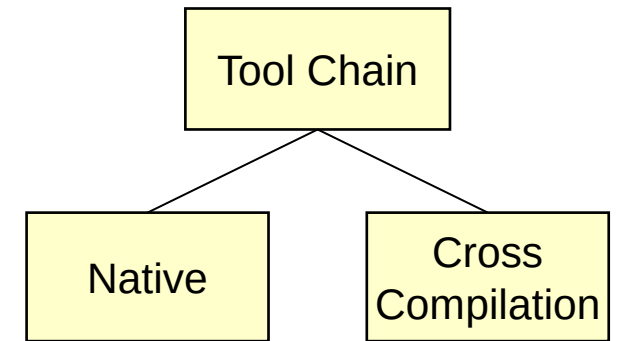


```
123 REG_TIMx_PSC(TIM4_BASE) = (F_84MHZ / F_10KHZ)-1;
124 REG_TIMx_ARR(TIM4_BASE) = F_10KHZ - 1;
125 REG_TIMx_CR1(TIM4_BASE) = 0x0;
126 REG_TIMx_CR1(TIM4_BASE) |= DOWNCOUNT;
127 REG_TIMx_DIER(TIM4_BASE) |= UIE;
128 REG_TIMx_CR1(TIM4_BASE) |= CEN;
```

Tool Chain

- **Tool chain**

- Minimal view
 - The set of tools that is required to create from source code an executable for a given environment
- Native tool chain
 - Builds for the same architecture where it runs on
- Cross compiler tool chain
 - Builds for another architecture than the one it runs on
 - E.g. build on PC for the CT Board (bare-metal ARM)
- Professional view: there is more than the “compiler & linker”:
 - Editing tools (IDE), revision control tools, documentation tools, testing tools, build tools, deployment tools, issue tracking tools, ...



Libraries

- **Libraries in general**

- Collection of object files
- May speedup linking
 - May provide an overall prepared (sorted) symbol table
- Linking with libraries may result in smaller code
 - Libraries may provide only the really needed parts of the sections
 - Linking with plain object files always links all and the whole sections
- Created by a librarian tool (e.g. armar for our environment)
- May replace one library by another one
 - E.g. at evaluation time have a working model, at production time have a high-performance library of the same functionality

Libraries

- **Static libraries**

- Executable is completely linked with a static library at link time
- The resulting executable is self contained
 - No need for any other libraries at run time
- Benefit
 - Self contained
 - No version issues in the run environment
 - No support needed from any hosting OS
- Drawback
 - Larger executables compared to dynamically linked libraries
 - No possibility to share common code between different executables
 - Cannot replace broken shared code with a new version of the library

- **ARM**

- Static libraries are used in the ARM cross compilation environment

Libraries

- **Dynamic or shared libraries**
 - Executable is not linked with a dynamic library at link time
 - The resulting executable is not self contained
 - Needs other libraries at run time
 - Loader of hosting OS links at load time with the shared libraries
 - Benefit
 - Smaller executables compared with static libraries
 - Can replace shared libraries
 - Drawback
 - May result in versioning problems at load time
 - Well known “DLL-Hell” from MS Windows environment
- **Windows/Unix/OSx**
 - With PC OS support you have generally both libraries
 - Static: libX.a, dynamic: libX.so (Unix/Linux/OSx), libX.dll (Windows)

Debugging

- **Single stepping**

- Support by the HW (stops processor, provides register access)
- Support by SW (swap instructions with a breakpoint instruction)

- **Source level debugging**

- Source level debugging needs mapping between
 - Machine address and source code line
 - Memory locations and source code types
- Mapping information is often also provided in object files (e.g. in the ELF files)
 - Also depends on all linking steps (merging section, resolve symbols, relocate symbol usage)
 - On Windows, this information is provided in a separate file (PDB)

Conclusions

- **Modular programming**
 - Crucial concept of software development
 - There is no golden rule but established practice
 - C supports this by use of header files and compilation into object files
- **Linker**
 - Combines object files into executable by merging sections, resolve referenced symbols and relocating all symbols and code
 - Is ignorant of the used programming language
- **Tools**
 - Tool chains and further tools build the working environment
- **Debugging**
 - Source-level debugging is a crucial tool to analyze and fix bugs